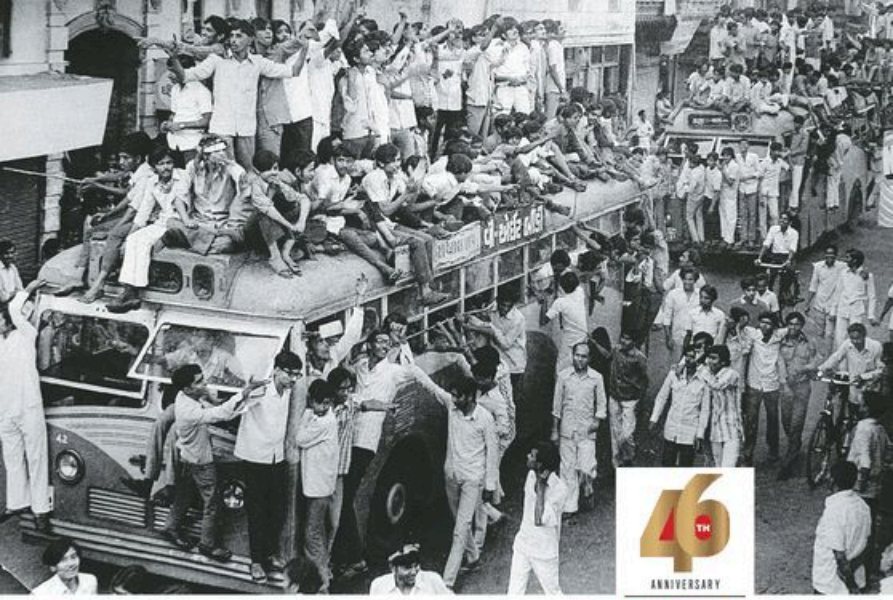


▲ Students' protest in Ahmedabad, 1974

46TH ANNIVERSARY

YOUTH UPRISINGS

A NEW AWAKENING

NAV NIRMAN ANDOLAN, 1973-74

Gujarat

The Nav Nirman movement gave a platform to the people who were fed up with the food insecurity, unemployment and corruption

What began as a protest by the students of the Ahmedabad University against high mess bills and poor quality of food soon became a mass movement against the corrupt government of Chief Minister Chimanbhai Patel. The Ahmedabad University students called for a strike on January 7, 1974. But fed up of food insecurity, unemployment and corruption, the isolated protest on one campus became a rallying cry for students across Gujarat.

The call for a bandh on January 10, 1974 in Ahmedabad and Vadodara (then Baroda) led to two days of riots. It was followed by a call for another statewide bandh on January 25, 1974. Sensing the people's anger, the then prime minister Indira Gandhi asked Patel to step down on February 9. By March 1974, 95 of 167 MLAs had resigned. On March 12, 1974, the then Congress leader Morarji Desai went on an indefinite hunger strike. Four days later, the assembly was dissolved, marking the end of the movement.

The Nav Nirman movement was perhaps the first in India that led to the ouster of an elected government. Though it didn't last the course, it became a precursor for Jayaprakash Narayan's 'Sampoorna Kranti (Total Revolution)', which led to the imposition of the Emergency in 1975. ■

–Kiran D. Tare

A TASK ACCOMPLISHED

The Nav Nirman movement petered out with Chimanbhai Patel's ouster not before influencing JP's Sampoorna Kranti. Some 16 years on, Patel returned as CM in March 1990, supported by BJP